

# Cool FFmpeg Tricks

FFmpeg is a free software project that creates libraries and programs to handle multimedia data. It includes libavcodec, an audio/video codec library. FFmpeg is a complete solution for recording, converting and streaming audio and video files.



Sometimes, fans of free software have to jump through many hoops to get to the good stuff. FFmpeg is one such example. Like the VLC media player, FFmpeg can handle almost any audio or video format you throw at it. Yet, most people have not even heard about it. Once you have compiled and installed it, it will prove to be pretty useful.

FFmpeg bills itself as a *complete solution to record, convert and stream audio and video*. The FFmpeg project provides four simple apps - `ffprobe`, `ffmpeg`, `ffplay` and `ffserver`. Many audio/video applications use it internally. If not directly, then via `mencoder`, FFmpeg is used by lots of media players, browser plugins, audio/video editors and other multimedia software. This article will focus on the `ffmpeg` binary executable, which can be used to convert audio/video files from one format to another.

## Compiling FFmpeg

Because many audio/video codecs are encumbered by software patents, GNU/Linux distributions have had to omit FFmpeg or bundle a less-capable FFmpeg version of it. Even if it were compiled with support for non-free encoders/decoders, there

would be a risk of a licence violation. Recently, FFmpeg released its Version 3 with a totally native AAC encoder, but more work remains. The solution was for users to do their own compilation. The *FFmpeg Wiki* site has compilation steps for several distributions. The compilation process does take a while to finish, but it will eventually create the four binary executable files. Copy them to your `/usr/bin` directory. If you don't want to disturb the FFmpeg installation that came with your Linux distribution, then you can access the binaries by providing their full path from a different directory.

While this FFmpeg installation covers most formats, I found that it would not encode to the audio codec of the undocumented AMV format. AMV is used by many cheap Chinese-made media players. These tiny devices are primarily FM and MP3 players with the video option added as a 'please ignore it' extra. The video resolution is a luxurious 160x120! I bought one of these players without realising all this. Fortunately, there was a Google Code project called *amv-codec-tools* that provided support for AMV using an old version of FFmpeg. If you need to work with this format, then build a custom FFmpeg binary, specially made for AMV,